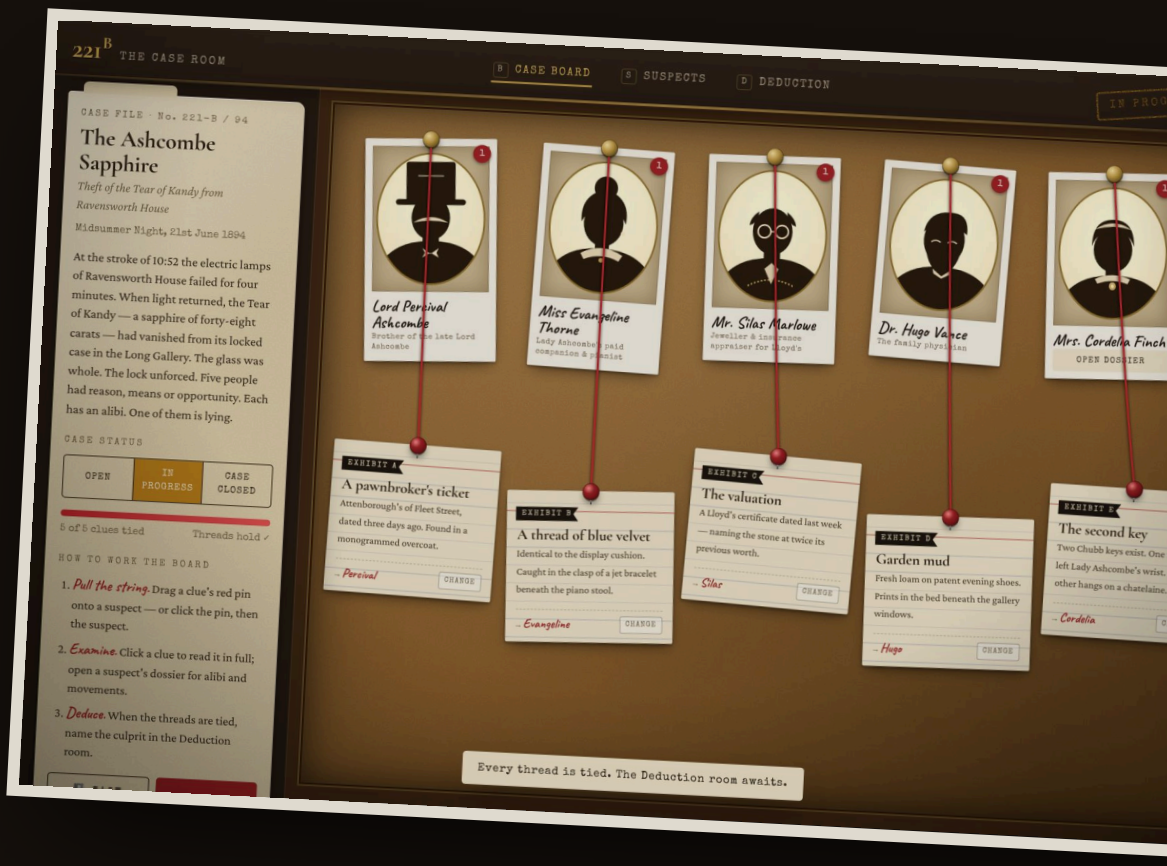
VISITOR'S GUIDE · CASE FILE NO. 221-B / 94

The 221B *Case Room*

An interactive detective board for the theft of the Ashcombe Sapphire. Five suspects, five alibis, five clues — and one liar.

OPEN IT IN ANY BROWSER

jaytech3.github.io/221b-case-room



Works on desktop browsers. No install, no sign-in, no data leaves your machine — your board, notes and verdicts are saved locally in the browser.

01 · THE IDEA

A detective's evidence board you can actually work.

Midsummer Night, 1894. At 10:52 pm the electric lamps of Ravensworth House fail for four minutes. When light returns, the Tear of Kandy — a sapphire of forty-eight carats — has vanished from its locked case in the Long Gallery. The glass is whole. The lock unforced.

The Case Room gives you the classic corkboard: suspects on polaroids, clues on index cards, and red string to tie one to the other. Behind it sit three screens, each answering one question a detective asks.

CASE BOARD

What do I know?

See every clue and every suspect at once. Pull string from a clue to the person it implicates. Track the case: Open → In Progress → Case Closed.

SUSPECT PROFILE

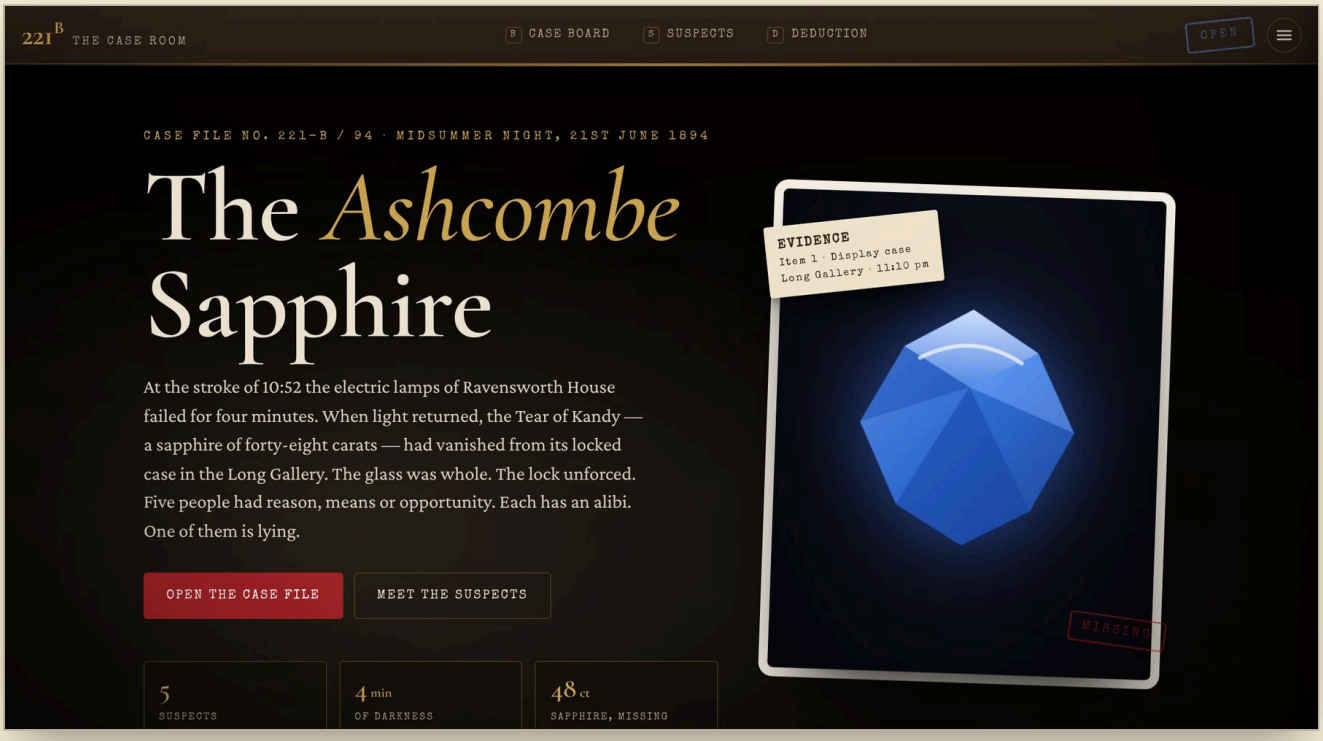
Does the alibi hold?

Statement, witnesses, the evidence against them, their movements that night, a short interrogation, your suspicion gauge and handwritten notes.

DEDUCTION

Who did it?

The household assembled at midnight. Pick a suspect, review your chain of reasoning, press and hold to accuse. A typewritten verdict answers.

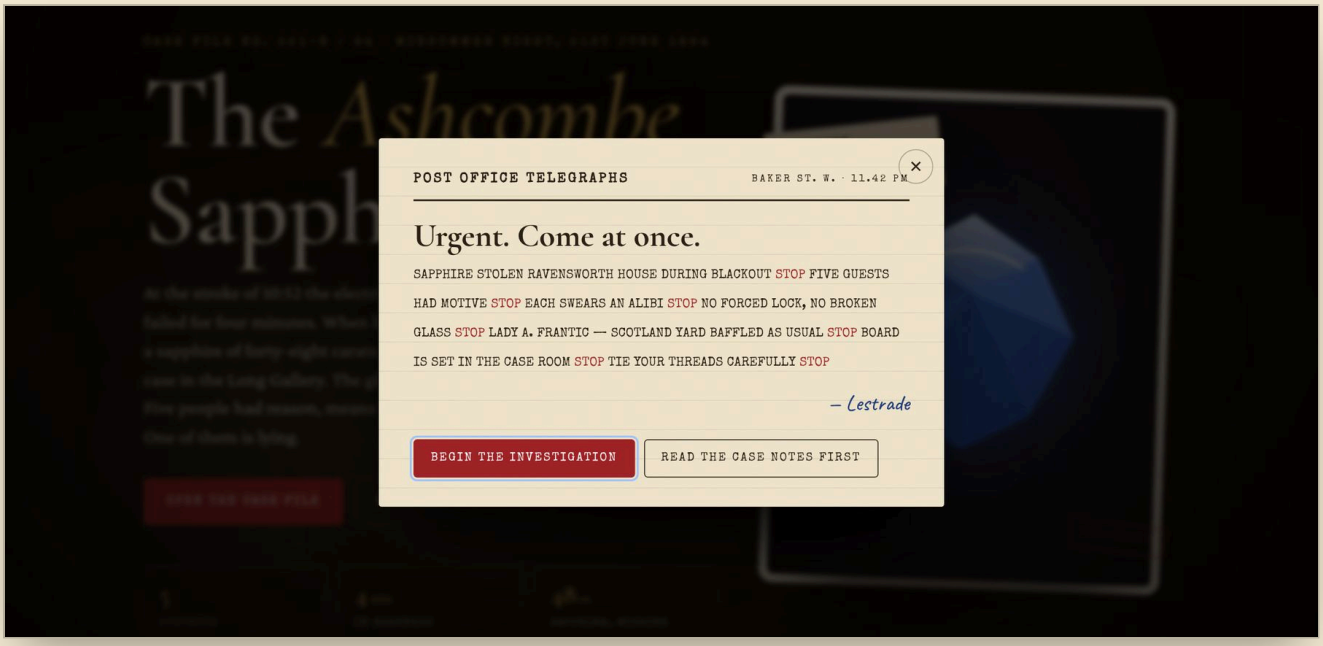


The opening screen. “Open the case file” takes you to the board; the page remembers where you left off.

Fifteen minutes from telegram to verdict.

I Read the telegram.

Inspector Lestrade's wire sets the scene. “Begin the investigation” drops you onto the board; “Read the case notes first” opens the notebook with the established facts and the timeline of the night. Everything you need to solve the case is in that timeline.



The telegram appears once. Re-read it any time from the ☰ menu.

2 Survey the board.

Five polaroids along the top, five evidence cards below. Drag any card to rearrange the board — it stays where you put it. Click a polaroid to open the dossier; click a clue card to read it in full. The folder on the left shows the case status and how many threads you have tied.



The pulsing ring on Exhibit A's pin is a nudge: that is where the string starts.

Pull the string.

3 Tie a clue to a suspect.

Grab the red pin on a clue card and drag it onto a polaroid. The suspect lights up when you are over them; release to tie. Prefer clicking? Click the pin, then click a suspect. Or open the clue and choose from the “Tie this thread to…” list.



Mid-drag: the dashed string follows the cursor; the target polaroid glows blue.

4 Watch the knots.

A string that fits the evidence snaps taut and red; a doubtful one turns amber and dashed, and the card says so. Hover a string and click the scissors to cut it. The progress bar in the folder counts threads that hold.



All five threads tied. Tallies on the polaroids count the clues pointing at each suspect.

Examine the evidence. Keep the notebook open.

5 Examine a clue.

Each exhibit opens as a full evidence sheet: the detail, what it suggests, and the chooser to tie or cut the thread. The clues never name their suspect outright — a monogram, a bracelet, a signature — so you read the dossiers to know whom they implicate.

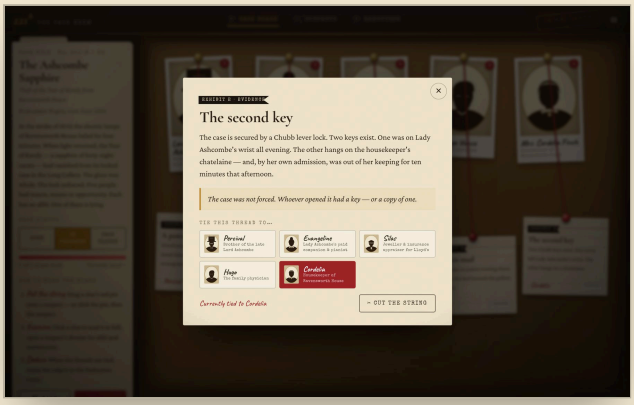
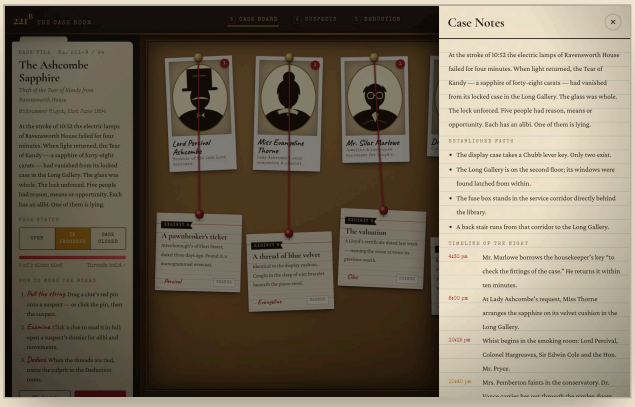


Exhibit E, the second key.

6 Open the case notes.

Press N or use the menu. The notebook holds the established facts, the timeline of the night, and a live list of your threads. The amber times mark the window of the theft.



The timeline. One line in it breaks one alibi.

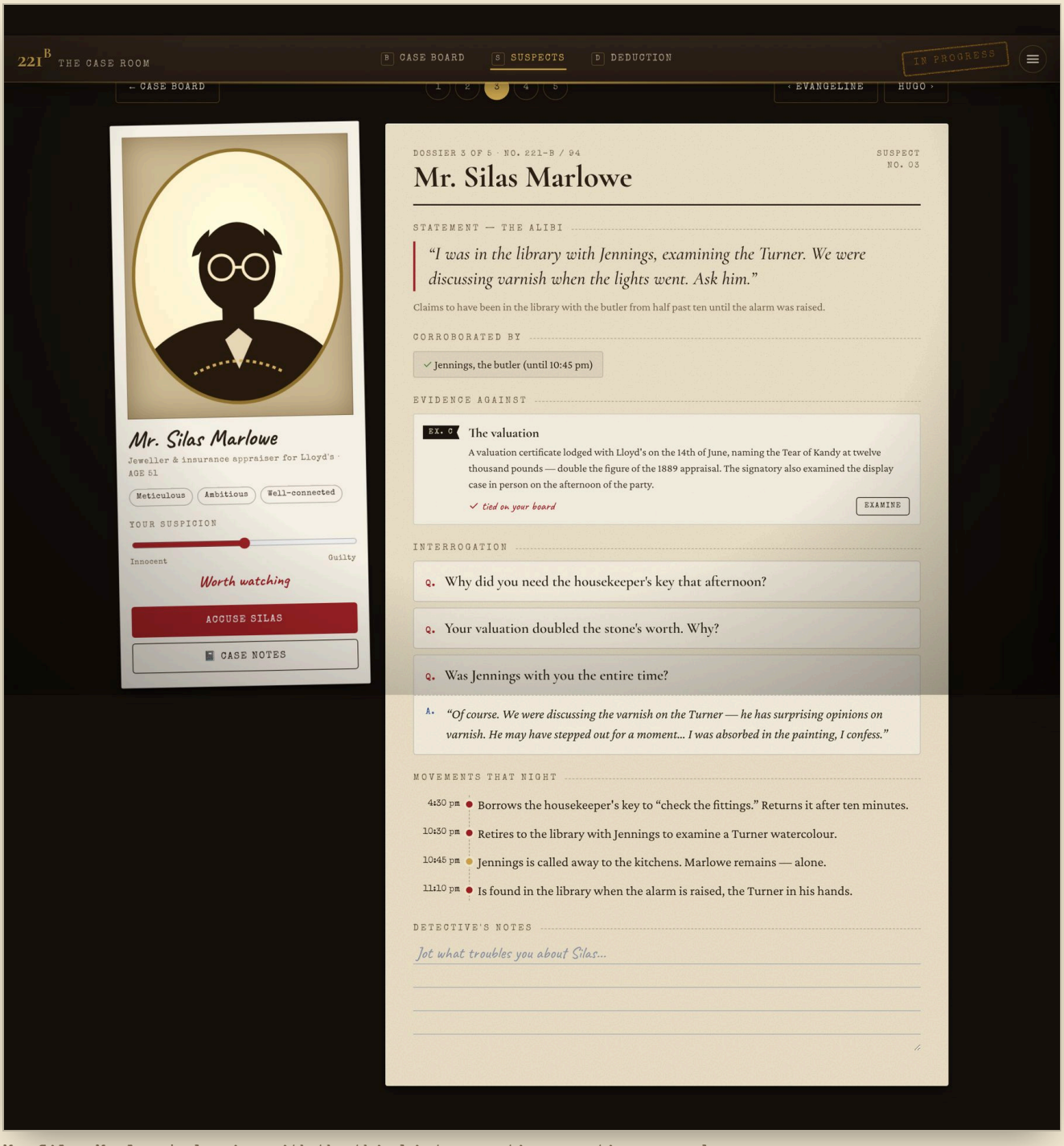
Detective's tip — when a suspect's alibi names a witness, find out where that witness was at 10:52. Witnesses have timelines too.

Read the dossier.

7

Open a suspect profile.

Click any polaroid, press 1–5, or use the Suspects tab. The mugshot card on the left carries the portrait, role, traits and your suspicion gauge; the sheet on the right carries the statement, who corroborates it, the evidence against them, an interrogation, their movements that night and a lined page for your own notes. Everything you type is saved.

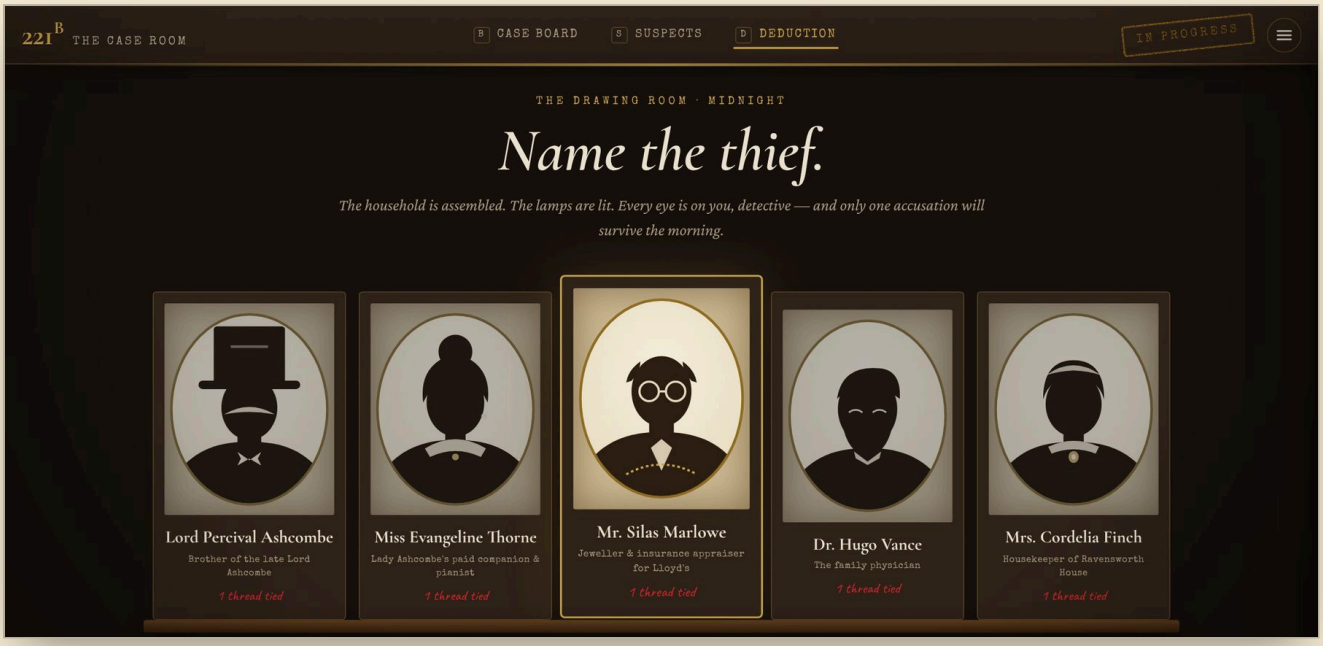


Mr. Silas Marlowe's dossier with the third interrogation question opened.

Name the thief.

8 Assemble the household.

The Deduction room lines up all five under the lamps. Click a suspect: the sheet below shows the case against them — the threads you tied, your notes, your suspicion, and who vouches for them. The board does not have to be complete to accuse, but it warns you if it isn't.



Marlowe selected; the lantern glow follows your choice.

9 Press and hold.

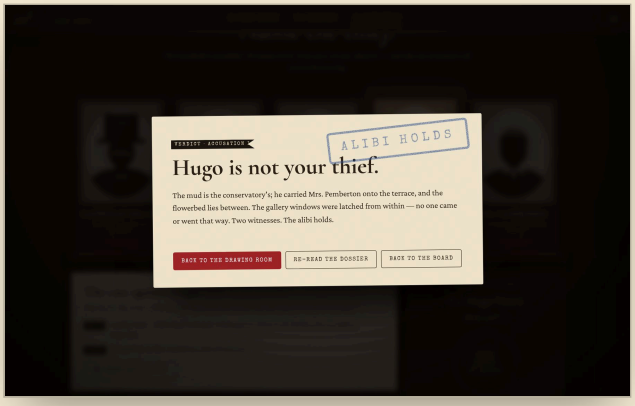
Two full seconds on the brass button. The ring fills; let go early and nothing happens. There is no accidental accusation and no taking it back.



Halfway through the hold.

10 Hear the verdict.

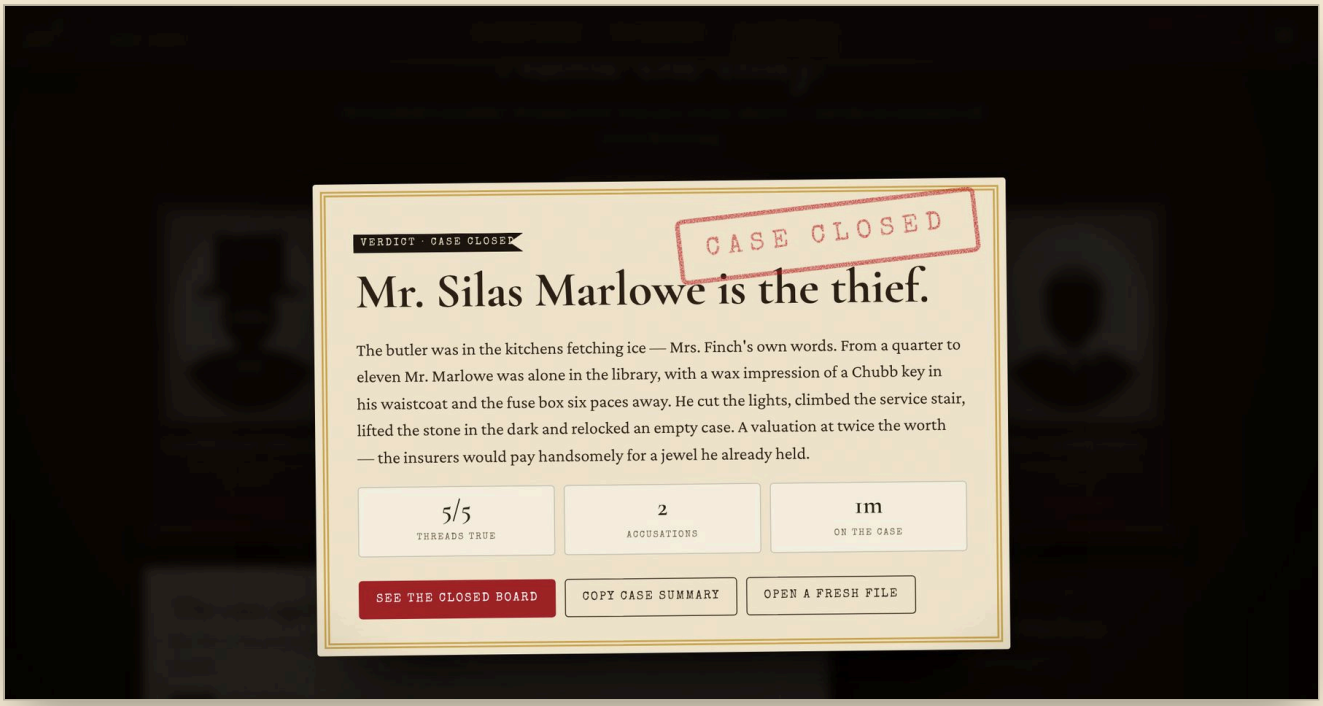
The verdict types itself out. Name the wrong person and they are stamped *Alibi Holds*, the case stays open and the lineup remembers who has been cleared. Name the right one and the file closes.



A wrong accusation. The explanation says why the alibi survives.

Case closed.

The right name earns the CASE CLOSED stamp, a full account of how the theft was done, and your figures: how many of your threads were true, how many accusations it took, and how long you were on the case. “Copy case summary” puts a shareable text on the clipboard; “Open a fresh file” resets the board for the next detective.



The closing verdict, with the stats row.



Back on the board: the culprit's string turns to gold, the guilty stamp lands, and the status reads Case Closed.

Five suspects. Five alibis.

SUSPECT	WHO THEY ARE	WHERE THEY SAY THEY WERE	THE CLUE AGAINST THEM
Lord Percival Ashcombe, 44	Brother of the late Lord Ashcombe. Gambler, in debt.	At whist in the smoking room with three gentlemen from 10:15 until after midnight.	**A** — a pawnbroker's ticket in a coat monogrammed P. A.
Miss Evangeline Thorne, 27	Lady Ashcombe's paid companion and pianist.	At the piano in the ballroom before forty guests; stopped when the lamps failed, resumed when they returned.	**B** — a thread of blue velvet from the display cushion, caught in a jet bracelet.
Mr. Silas Marlowe, 51	Jeweller and insurance appraiser for Lloyd's.	In the library with Jennings the butler, examining a Turner.	**C** — a valuation at twice the stone's worth, signed a week before the party.
Dr. Hugo Vance, 38	The family physician.	Attending Mrs. Pemberton, who fainted in the conservatory at 10:40.	**D** — fresh garden mud on his evening shoes; prints beneath the gallery windows.
Mrs. Cordelia Finch, 59	Housekeeper, thirty years' service.	In the kitchens overseeing supper for forty.	**E** — the only duplicate key to the case, on her chatelaine.

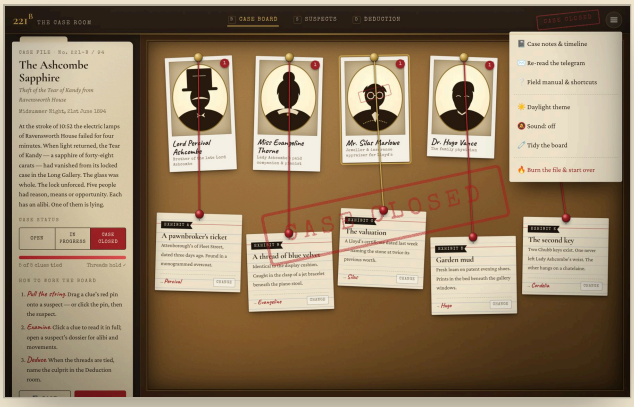
Established facts

The display case takes a Chubb lever key; only two exist. The Long Gallery is on the second floor and its windows were latched from within. The fuse box stands in the service corridor directly behind the library, and a back stair runs from that corridor to the gallery.

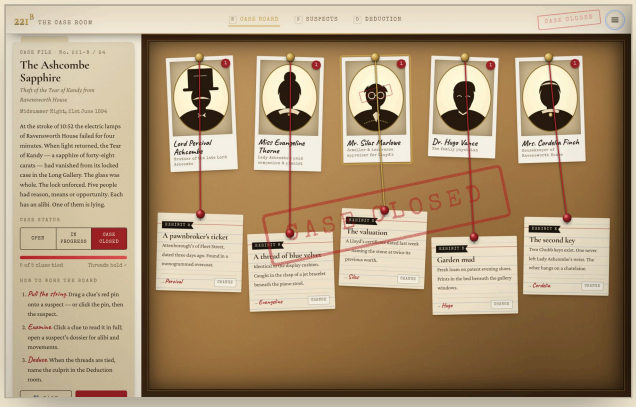
The night, in order

4:30 pm	Mr. Marlowe borrows the housekeeper's key “to check the fittings.” Returns it within ten minutes.
8:00 pm	Miss Thorne arranges the sapphire on its cushion at Lady Ashcombe's request.
10:15 pm	Whist begins in the smoking room.
10:40 pm	Mrs. Pemberton faints; Dr. Vance carries her out through the garden doors.
10:45 pm	Jennings is summoned from the library to the kitchens for ice; he stays until 11:05.
10:52 pm	The lamps fail. The piano falls silent.
10:56 pm	A footman replaces the fuse. The piano resumes.
11:10 pm	The case is found locked — and empty.

Small things worth noticing.



The ☰ menu: notes, telegram, field manual, theme, sound, tidy, reset.



Daylight theme — the same board by day.

FEATURE	WHAT IT DOES
Case status	Open → In Progress → Case Closed. Moves on its own as you work, or set it by hand in the folder. The stamp in the header always shows it.
Everything persists	Board layout, strings, notes, suspicion, verdicts and theme are saved in the browser. Close the tab and come back; the landing page offers to resume.
Gaslight / Daylight	Two full themes. Gaslight is the default.
Sound	Off by default. Turn it on for pin pushes, string snaps, typewriter ticks and the stamp.
Tidy the board	Puts every card back where it started without touching your strings.
Burn the file	Full reset, with a confirmation. Theme and sound settings survive.
Print	Print any dossier and it comes out as a clean paper file.
Accessibility	Everything is reachable by keyboard; modals return focus; reduced-motion is respected; status changes are announced.

Keyboard

`B` board `S` suspects `D` deduction `N` case notes `1`–`5` open a dossier `?` field manual
`Esc` close / cancel a string `Enter` on a card opens it

05 · UNDER THE HOOD

Built by hand, hosted for free.

How it is made

Plain HTML, CSS and vanilla JavaScript — no framework, no build step, five files. Portraits are inline SVG cameos; the cork, paper and rubber-stamp textures are procedural SVG filters. Fonts come from Google Fonts: Cormorant Garamond, Crimson Pro, Special Elite and Caveat.

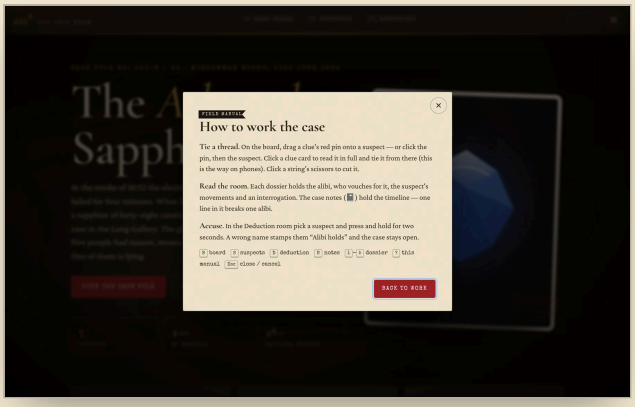
Where it lives

Source on GitHub, deployed to GitHub Pages by a workflow on every push to `main`.

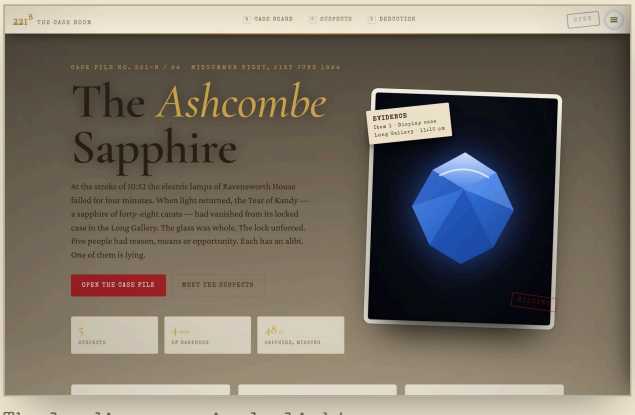
`github.com/jaytech3/221b-case-room`
`jaytech3.github.io/221b-case-room`

Write your own case

All content — suspects, alibis, clues, interrogations, timeline and verdicts — lives in one data file. Change the answer on each clue and the guilty flag on one suspect, and the board becomes a new mystery.



The field manual, one keystroke away.



The landing page in daylight.

SUGGESTED SESSION FOR A GROUP

Project the board. Give everyone five minutes with the dossiers and the case notes. Tie the strings together, arguing each knot. Then let one person press and hold — and make them say why before the ring fills.

The solution.

Stop here if you intend to play.

Mr. Silas Marlowe, the appraiser.

His alibi rests on Jennings the butler. But Mrs. Finch's dossier — and the timeline — have Jennings in the kitchens from 10:45 until 11:05, fetching ice. From a quarter to eleven Marlowe was alone in the library. The fuse box is in the service corridor behind that library; the back stair runs from the corridor to the gallery. He had borrowed the housekeeper's key that afternoon for “ten minutes” and taken a wax impression. He cut the lights, climbed the stair, lifted the stone in the dark, relocked the case, and was back with the Turner in his hands when the alarm was raised. The valuation at twice the stone's worth was the point: the insurers would pay handsomely for a jewel he already held.

Why the others hold

Percival	Three gentlemen swear he never left the whist table; the Colonel took eleven pounds off him during the blackout alone. The pawn ticket proves debt, not theft.
Thorne	Forty guests heard the piano stop and resume within the minute; the gallery is two floors up by the main stair. The velvet thread dates from dressing the cushion at eight.
Vance	The mud is the flowerbed between the conservatory and the terrace; the gallery windows were latched from inside. Two witnesses.
Finch	She lent the key and admitted it. The cook, two maids and, from 10:45, Jennings place her among forty covers all evening.

The intended string

`A → Percival · B → Thorne · C → Marlowe · D → Vance · E → Finch`